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# jQuery traversing 10m

In jQuery, traversing means moving through or over the HTML elements to find, filter or select a particular or entire element. Compared to plain JavaScript, jQuery makes this traversing easier.

The structure of an HTML page is in the form of a DOM tree (refer to the figure below for a demonstration of a DOM tree). jQuery traversing is used to easily move up (to ancestors), down (to descendants) and sideways (to siblings) through the tree. This is called traversing the DOM tree.



If you need a refresher about this, we recommend taking a look at the following pages:

[Document Object Model \(DOM\) →](#)

- jQuery traversing refers to a process of **moving through** the DOM to find specific HTML elements.
- This search depends on the **relations** between elements.
- jQuery provides multiple methods for **traversing** the DOM conveniently and dynamically.

In summary, jQuery traversing means that you apply specific methods to retrieve information on **relations** between HTML elements.

To understand traversing (moving through) a DOM tree, you need to understand the terms ancestors, descendants and siblings.

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### 1. Ancestors

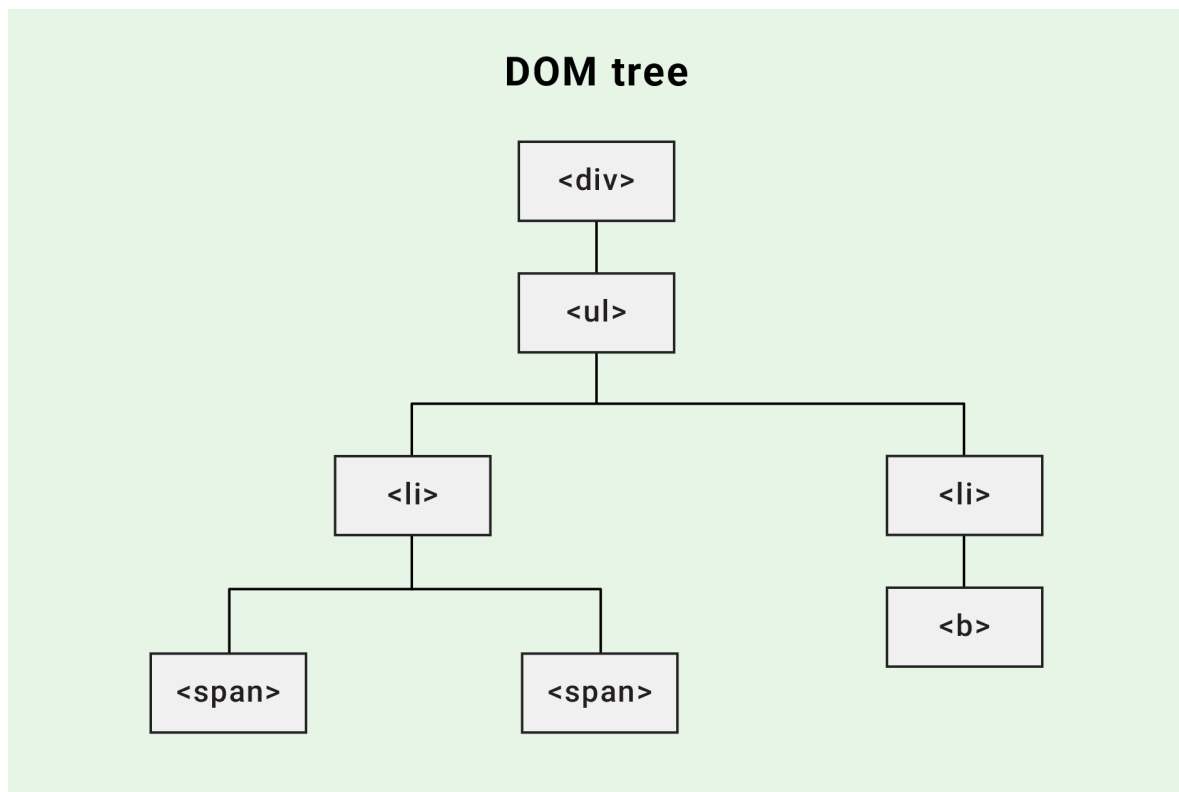
- Using jQuery, you can travel up a DOM tree to find the ancestors of an element.
- An ancestor can be the parent, grandparent or great-grandparent of an element.

### 2. Descendants

- Using jQuery, you can travel down a DOM tree to find descendants of an element.
- A descendant can be the child, grandchild or great-grandchild of an element.

### 3. Siblings

- Using jQuery, you can travel sideways on a DOM tree to find the siblings of an element.
- Sibling elements will share a parent.



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The figure illustrates the structure of an HTML page using a DOM tree. You can see that the layout has a clear structure. We can explain the figure using the terms we've just discussed:

- `<div>` is the **parent** of `<ul>` and an **ancestor** to every other element in the DOM tree.
- `<ul>` is the **parent** to the `<li>` elements, as well as a **child** to `<div>`.
- The left `<li>` and right `<li>` are **siblings** because they have a shared **parent**.
- The left `<li>` is the **parent** to both `<span>` elements, **child** to `<ul>` and a **descendant** of `<div>`.
- The right `<li>` is the **parent** to `<b>`, **child** of `<ul>` and a **descendant** of `<div>`.
- The `<span>` elements are **siblings** to each other, **children** of `<li>` and **descendants** of `<div>` and `<ul>`.

## jQuery traversing methods

So, how does jQuery traverse the DOM? jQuery has several methods to traverse DOM elements. There are jQuery methods for traversing up, down and sideways in the DOM tree.

| Category                   | Traversing method     | Description                                | Syntax                              |
|----------------------------|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| Ancestors<br>(traverse up) | <code>parent()</code> | Gives parent element of specified selector | <code>\$(selector).parent();</code> |

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|                                |                |                                                                                                   |                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|--------------------------------|----------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Ancestors<br>(traverse up)     | parentsUntil() | Gives all ancestor elements between specified selector and arguments                              | <code>\$(selector).parentsUntil(selector, filter element)</code>                                                                                                                                      |
| Ancestors<br>(traverse up)     | offsetParent() | Gives the first positioned parent element of specified selector                                   | <code>\$(selector).offsetParent();</code>                                                                                                                                                             |
| Ancestors<br>(traverse up)     | closest()      | Gives the first ancestor of the specified selector                                                | <code>\$(selector).closest(selector);</code><br><code>\$(selector).closest(selector, context);</code><br><code>\$(selector).closest(selection);</code><br><code>\$(selector).closest(element);</code> |
| Descendants<br>(traverse down) | children()     | Gives the children of each selected element; optionally filtered by a selector                    | <code>\$(selector).children();</code>                                                                                                                                                                 |
| Descendants<br>(traverse down) | find()         | Gives descendant elements of specified elements, filtered by a selector, jQuery object or element | <code>\$(selector).find('selector to find');</code>                                                                                                                                                   |

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|                                    |                         |                                                                       |                                       |
|------------------------------------|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Siblings<br>(traverse<br>sideways) | <code>siblings()</code> | Gives all<br>siblings of<br>the specified<br>selector                 | <code>\$(selector).siblings();</code> |
| Siblings<br>(traverse<br>sideways) | <code>next()</code>     | Gives the next<br>sibling<br>element of<br>the specified<br>selector  | <code>\$(selector).next();</code>     |
| Siblings<br>(traverse<br>sideways) | <code>nextAll()</code>  | Gives all next<br>sibling<br>elements of<br>the specified<br>selector | <code>\$(selector).nextAll();</code>  |



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## Dig deeper

To learn more about jQuery traversing, read these resources (W3Schools, n.d.).

- jQuery traversing
  - jQuery traversing - ancestors
  - jQuery traversing - descendants
  - jQuery traversing - siblings
  - jQuery traversing - filtering.



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Thoughts on this page?

